

US TMC Conference

Feedback on US wireless, the satellite debate, and AI related upside

Over the last two days, JPMorgan has hosted its (ongoing) 54th TMC conference in Boston. Key feedback, as it pertains to our EMEA coverage universe, includes: **(1) US wireless:** Investors remain a little nervous on near-term competitive unknowns given Verizon's planned Q2 tariff refresh, and CEO Schulman's insistence that his FY net adds guide is conservative. That said, the bigger picture (for us) was that the BIG3 seem collectively confident in their growth outlooks, which are more centered around driving share gains across new TAMs (FWA, fibre, convergence), and leveraging AI to accelerate cost efficiencies as well as reduce churn, **(2) Satellites:** Reassuring messages, with the BIG3 stressing they have no appetite to offer satellite operators an MVNO, that D2D volumes are extremely low (just 0.0002% of TMUS' total network traffic), and that satellite is in their minds complementary, rather than a threat (a view reinforced by the BIG3 D2D JV), **(3) AI:** The most confident AI messages came from Twilio (its AI product stack is far superior to that of Sinch, but offers insights into what is possible should Sinch close the gap), and AMT (led by its datacentre unit CoreSite, but includes hopes of mid-term benefits to the tower ecosystem), **(4) DT:** On Monday ([here](#)) we argued DT's shares screened oversold, and we believe this supportive US conference feedback should see the recent rebound run further. That said, several unknowns remain, and furthermore we continue to see European consolidation plays as offering the most compelling risk-reward ahead. US Telcos are covered by Sebastiano Petti and US Towers by Richard Choe.

T-Mobile – Srin Gopalan (CEO)

Takeaways: **(1) Network perception:** The CEO believes this can drive years of ongoing share gains given an identified 20m+ addressable “network seeker”; **(2) ARPA growth:** Expect this to be supported by the fact that port-in ARPA is 20% higher than port-out ARPA (hence volume growth is accretive), expanding customer relationships, and thoughtful more-for-more pricing; **(3) SMRA:** Momentum to continue. Q1 share of 24% marked the 12th consecutive quarter of win-share leadership; **(4) FWA:** Reiterated guidance for 15m FWA customers by FY30E (underpinned by fallow capacity, without considering upside from new spectrum wins or technology driven improvements in spectral efficiency); **(5) Fibre:** TMUS remains disciplined, targeting double-digit IRRs and first-to-fiber areas. The CEO noted first year fibre penetration rates of ~20%, a preference for fibre ownership over wholesale deals, and that cable M&A is “structurally off the table” given cable's overpriced back book; **(6) DT-TMUS merger:** TMUS would not comment on “market speculation”, reiterating that under Delaware law, any such hypothetical transaction would require majority approval of disinterested shareholders; **(7) Satellite:** The recent D2D JV with Verizon and AT&T includes implementing satellite as a standard feature on premium rate plans, driving a uniform device ecosystem, and standardizing spectrum. TMUS reiterated that D2D is complementary to terrestrial wireless. The company sees no incremental TAM opportunity from offering satellite an MVNO arrangement, and noted satellite usage today is extremely limited (0.0002% of total network traffic).

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Verizon – Dan Schulman (CEO)

Key takeaways: **(1) Costs:** Want to be the most efficient Telco in the world. Already well on the way to cutting \$5bn in opex (with risk potentially to the upside), as well as \$4bn in capex (it seems there could even be room to cut further mid-term, depending somewhat on how much spectrum Verizon secures in upcoming auctions). But Schulman was clear that costs were an output, rather than an input, with the core objective being to “delight customers”; **(2) Driving change:** Schulman believes Verizon was historically too slow, too process orientated, and too risk averse. Today they are one of the 1st 30 companies to have worked with Anthropic, they are becoming AI-native, and they are working to drive major improvements to every layer of the customer experience. Churn in Q4 was 95bp. This fell to 90bp in Q1, and 85bp by the end of Q1. This is helping lower both the cost per gross add and retention costs. Over 50% of the FY net adds improvement will come from churn reductions; **(3) Q2 tariff refresh:** The CEO noted their targeted Q2 “valuation proposition refresh” has been worked on for some time. Whilst he did not provide any clear colour, he suggested it would be about changing “lots of small things” and being “fiscally responsible”. He noted a desire to move away from clumsy “free handset” offers to tools that create tangible, and durable, improvements in customer experience and satisfaction; **(4) Shareholder value:** The CEO noted Verizon in the past was a substitute for a bond yield given 20 years of ongoing dividend growth. But he now wants to pivot to driving a step function change in revenue and bottom-line growth, which in turn should deliver greater shareholder value; **(5) D2D partnership:** Seen as a pragmatic agreement that will eliminate deadzones, create standards for all satellite operators, and simplify the ecosystem. Like TMUS, Verizon also indicated no appetite for offering satellite operators an MVNO. Finally, Schulman argued he could not see satellites being anything but complimentary to wireless over the next 10 years given the vast differences in urban capacity.

AT&T – John Stankey (Chairman & CEO)

Takeaways: **(1) Fibre:** Lumen integration is progressing well. On further fibre M&A, AT&T reiterated no interest in fragmented “*postage stamp*” fiber assets, noting a preference for scaled, metro-dense fiber at fair value. That said, the CEO is also open to aggregating mismanaged assets cleansed through bankruptcy if any such opportunity arises. But for now, an organic strategy is the company’s focus; **(2) Churn:** AT&T believes the recent deterioration (attributed to competitor buy-out offers) should plateau as they have now worked through the base. Longer term, AT&T believes convergence can deliver “dramatic improvement[s] in churn and longevity”. On the value segment push, Stankey framed it as a network utilization decision (which he considers accretive to returns); **(3) Cable:** AT&T stressed that their fibre growth was coming from competitive wins, not base transition, given the absence of any remaining DSL base to harvest. The company also suggested cable-wireless bases may become increasingly vulnerable to fibre share gains; **(4) AI:** AT&T sees the company’s role across three layers: (i) Preferred access: Fiber has the lowest marginal cost, and is the most future-proofed technology for heavy workloads, which paired with EchoStar spectrum enables more symmetrical low-band upstream on wireless; (ii) Metro aggregation and backbone: Actively building shared dark and lit fiber infrastructure into hyperscaler access points; and (iii) Edge compute: A potential opportunity “if we think it makes sense” but conviction seemed low; **(5) D2D:** AT&T see satellite as a “great complement” with a seamless D2D product expected in 2H26. AT&T notes it would make no sense for the BIG3 to each separately lobby for spectrum harmonisation and shared network standards, nor for each to build out duplicate ground-station infrastructure. A detailed term sheet should materialise shortly, with the regulatory timeline a little more difficult to call.

Twilio – Aidan Viggiano (CFO)

Takeaways: **(1) AI-first:** Twilio has recently embedded several new AI capabilities to its offering which can now maintain one continuous customer conversation across all channels, remembers conversations/context, and leverages AI to turn conversations into actionable, real-time intelligence that enhances human agents and triggers immediate actions like automated workflows across voice and messaging channels; **(2) Q1 acceleration usage-led:** The company's organic growth in Q1 was broad-based across products and the recent acceleration was attributed to AI native offerings. On the 5% beat last quarter, management commented that they wouldn't see it as "kind of the new norm", however attributed it to their usage-based model; **(3) Q2 guide prudent:** On the debate regarding Q2 guide screening conservative, given it implies a deceleration in organic growth, management commented that *"it's pretty consistent with how we've guided... we're usage-based... we plan a bit more prudently"*. They also added that they *"feel really good about the opportunity ahead.. and about the setup for Q2 and the balance of the year"*.

AST – Scott Wisniewski (President & CSO)

Takeaways: **(1) Commercialisation:** 45+ satellites in orbit is the threshold needed to achieve full commercial service in priority markets like the US. D2D broad integration is expected from 2027 onward; **(2) Spectrum:** S-Band spectrum is being pursued opportunistically around the world, notably in Europe where licenses are underutilized. Since the company's satellites were being built regardless, the incremental cost of adding new spectrum bands is relatively low, enabling fast and strategic spectrum acquisition; **(3) Revenues:** Revenues are expected to grow sequentially each quarter toward \$150-200m in 2026, all from pre-commercial service activity. A roughly 50/50 split between government and commercial revenue is anticipated, with upside potential in both. More than half of the remaining 2026 guidance is already contracted, with the rest covered several times over by the pipeline; **(4) Backlog:** Minimum revenue commitments secured from operators, contributing \$100m+ per year across multi-year agreements (ranging from 2 to 10 years), spread pro-rata i.e. not back-end loaded; **(5) Outlook:** The company thinks it can reach positive operating FCF well before hitting \$1bn in revenue. Active in-orbit testing is underway for multiple US government revenue-producing opportunities.

AMT – Rodney Smith (EVP & CFO)

Takeaways: **(1) Outlook:** Mid-single-digit revenue growth in the US is expected to underpin industry-leading AFFO per share growth, complemented by faster growth in emerging markets and double-digit growth in the data center platform, collectively targeting mid to upper single-digit AFFO per share growth reliably; **(2) Europe:** The region is outperforming its original business case, with mid single-digit or better revenue growth expected. The portfolio is insulated from material one-time churn events, as the majority of revenue is tied to long-term contracts with Telefonica; **(3) LatAm:** The region is going through a consolidation. Hence 2026 marks peak churn, particularly in Brazil, which is transitioning to a three-carrier market. Starting next year, churn is expected to decrease rapidly with new business activity likely accelerating; **(4) Africa:** Upper single-digit organic tenant billings growth, even after absorbing a few hundred basis points of churn, which management views as a normal operating environment for the region; **(5) CoreSite:** Datacenter investments have been scaled up from \$200m to \$800m now. The long-term vision is to connect CoreSite facilities directly into tower assets, positioning the company to benefit from the convergence of mobile network densification and AI-driven edge compute demand. Capital reallocation in datacenters has been deliberate with investment appetite shifted away from emerging markets and toward the US and CoreSite; **(6) AI workloads:** These are increasingly tipping out of large language models, and hyperscale facilities, into edge facilities like CoreSite, which management views as a meaningful and growing source of upside. Future wireless network evolution will require uplink and downlink symmetry, improved latency, more

antennas, and compute power paired directly at tower sites, potentially including cloud on-ramps and interconnection capabilities.

SBA – Marc Montagner (EVP & CFO)

Takeaways: **(1) US:** Long-term US growth is framed as 3% escalators + 2.5-3% new lease activity from the big three MNOs - 1% churn, arriving 4.5-5% baseline growth rate, assuming a three-carrier market. Upside scenarios beyond the baseline include new use cases such as drone delivery, self-driving cars, and edge computing for AI inference, as well as potential satellite spectrum deployment, which management believes would be a net positive for tower demand. 6G expected in late 2028-2029, combined with new use cases and edge computing demand, could meaningfully exceed the current 3+3-1 growth framework over the long term; **(2) AI:** AI-driven latency requirements are expected to push compute closer to the network edge, creating potential incremental demand at tower sites; **(3) BTS:** New BTS rates offered by the big three carriers in the US were previously unattractive, leading SBA to largely sit out. However, the dialogue is shifting and conversations are resuming, with management willing to participate at the right returns; **(4) Brazil:** SBA could see peak churn this year due to Oi Mobile's consolidation, however churn is expected to persist for another ~2 years. The long-term outlook remains high single-digit growth, assuming ~5-6% CPI and ~4% lease-up; **(5) Shareholder returns:** Buybacks remain a priority. \$500m was spent on repurchases last year and management expect to lean toward buybacks again this year. The dividend was increased 13% last year with a ~41% payout ratio, and low-teens dividend growth is expected to be maintained for the next three years.

Uniti – Kenny Gunderman (CEO)

In April 2026, press reports speculated T-Mobile's interest in Uniti's Consumer fibre assets ([here](#)). The presentation covered (in great detail) Uniti's build strategy, competitive dynamics, business moats, and hyperscaler opportunity. Takeaways: **(1) Fibre:** Uniti's core strategy is to build fiber first, where no fiber exists, focusing on clustered strategic markets rather than a patchwork of builds across the country, in order to capture go-to-market, construction, and operational synergies; **(2) Q1 phasing:** Winter storms were cited as a partial reason for the Q1 slowdown, but March and April each saw ~45k homes built, which annualizes to 500k+ homes and is directionally where the company wants to be; **(3) Churn:** Fiber churn is tracking "better than expected" and is now a bonus metric; **(4) Overbuilders:** Altnets have largely stayed away from Uniti's footprint, as rural markets are harder to enter due to smaller addressable populations, limited backhaul options (Uniti is often the only provider and does not sell to overbuilders), and the company's strategy of building as fast as possible to raise barriers to entry; **(5) Cable:** Overlap exists in roughly 50% of the footprint, which is well below the industry average; **(6) Penetration:** The 40% long-term penetration guidance is viewed as increasingly conservative, with management noting that virtually all original model assumptions are proving prudent; **(7) Backbone:** Uniti's rural backbone infrastructure, built across Tier 2 and Tier 3 long-haul corridors, has proven to be strategically valuable to hyperscalers who are targeting those locations for land and power accessibility. This gives Uniti a deployment speed and cost advantage, as 80% of hyperscaler deals involve selling existing infrastructure or infrastructure attached to existing routes. **(8) Outlook:** The company is targeting ~\$1.5bn of revenue from anchor hyperscaler builds over the next several years, expected to generate ~\$500m of recurring revenue, representing a meaningful share of what management estimates to be a \$75bn TAM for fiber companies. Management noted these numbers could be larger when revisited next year; **(9) IRRs:** Blended IRR on anchor plus lease-up hyperscaler economics is tracking at 30%.

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